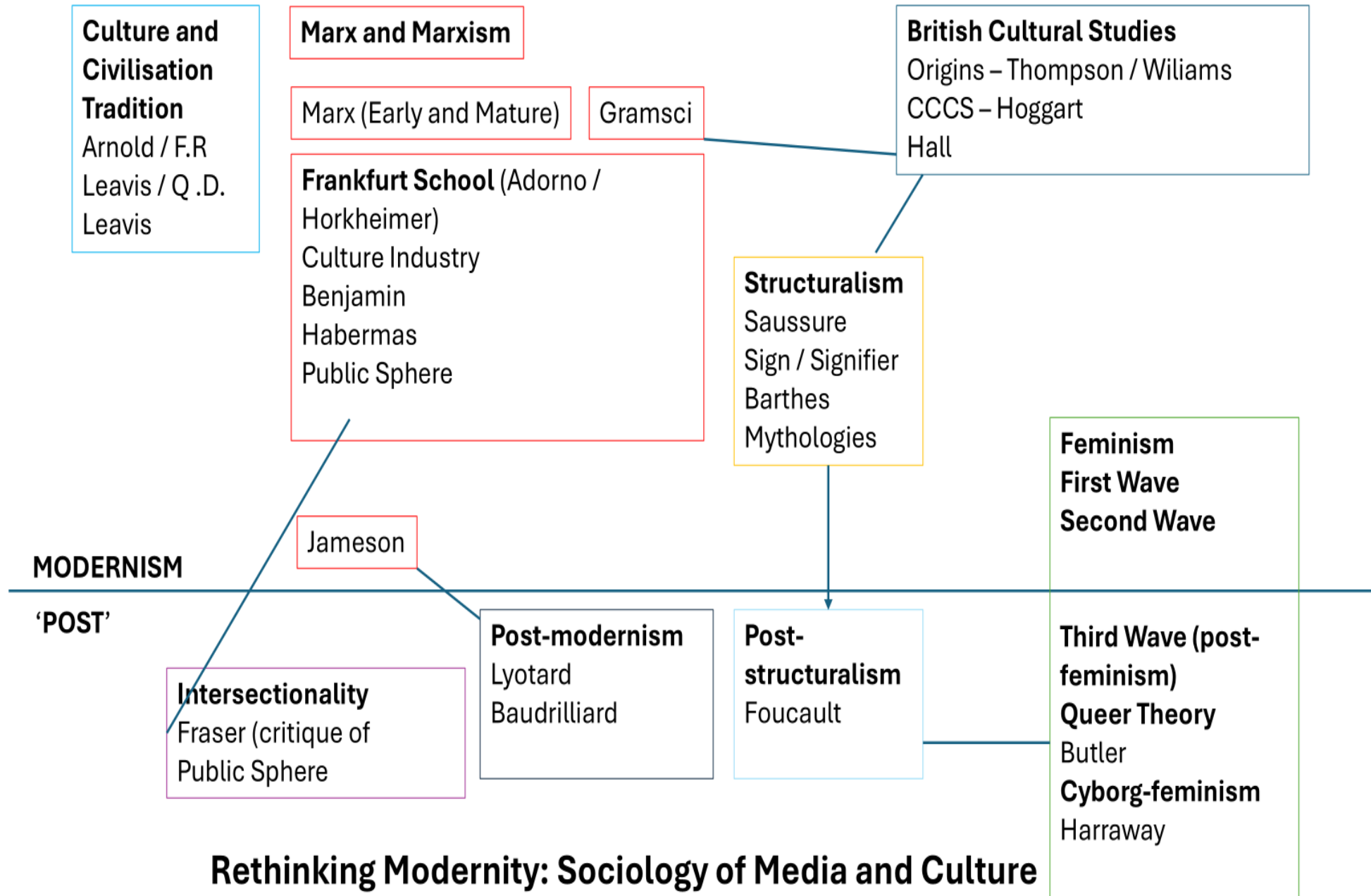




Structuralism, post-structuralism, post-modernism

Structuralism – single and stable meaning , objective reality, epistemology

Signifier → Signified



Sign

Referent

Post-structuralism: meaning is not stable, dependent on interpretation, multiple truths and meanings, reality is socially constructed, no universal truth.

Post-modernism: after modernity, many movements including post-structuralism. May suggest post-modern methods of resistance or nihilism.





Lyotard: the post-modern
condition and media
(The Post-Modern Condition: A
Report on Knowledge, 1979)

What is post-modernism

- End of grand narratives (of modernism)
- Technological mediation
- End of modernist epistemology / science – **Language games and performativity**
- Knowledge becomes fragmented and plural
- Mixture of styles / identities / consumption patterns
- Little narratives / local narratives
- University becomes transformed

Lyotard on post-modernism and media

- Performativity governs media
- Knowledge becomes information
- Media supports / undermines grand-narratives
- There is no final authority of the media





Postmodern culture

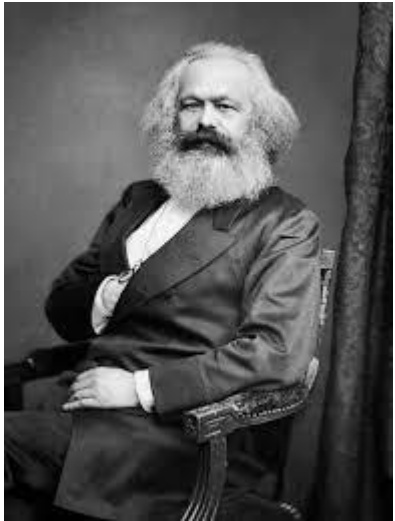
- “Eclecticism is the degree zero of contemporary general culture: you listen to reggae, you watch a western, you eat McDonald’s at midday and local cuisine at night, you wear Paris perfume in Tokyo and retro clothes in Hong Kong” (Lyotard)

Baudrillard: consumption,
hypermarket, hyperreal
(Simulcra and Simulation, 1981)

Popular culture: commodity, market, hyperreality

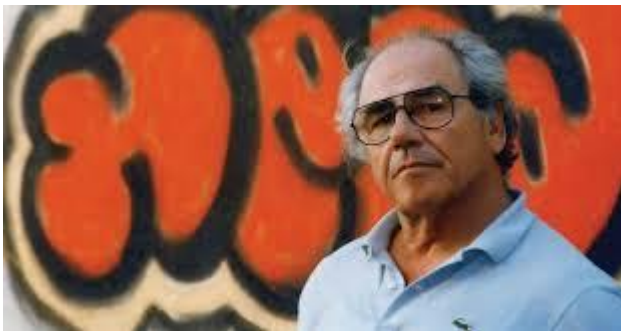


Marx vs Baudrillard on the commodity



Use value
Exchange value

Sign value



‘The sign object is neither given nor exchanged:
it is appropriated, withheld and manipulated by
individual subjects as a sign, that is as a coded
difference’

Culturally the object exists within the world of other sign objects...



...the media displays that a miracle may happen...



...the subject is brought into the world of events. But is kept distant from reality...

...within a dizzying whirl of reality...



...but media is the site of the playing out of our desires



The hypermarket as the site of symbolic exchange



- Temporal / spatial distortion
- Triage centres
- New geographical and
- experiential space
- Consumers are tested
- Playful / whimsical
- Hyperreality
- Universities as hypermarket
- Other places as hypermarket

Four levels of simulation

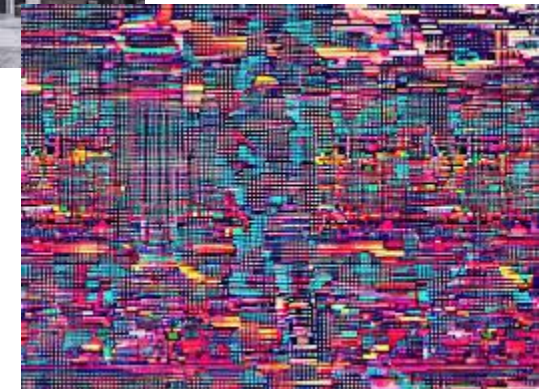
Beyond the 'real'

First order: Obvious copy of reality

Second order: Copy so good it blurs the boundaries of representation and reality

Third order: Produces a reality of its own without being based on any aspect of the real world (**Simulacra** produced by a process of **simulation**. **Hyperreality** is where the distinction between the real and the model disappears (more real than the real).

Fourth Order: Pure Simulacrum (no representation to reality)





Stage One:

Initially, the sign (image or representation) is a reflection of basic reality.



Stage Two:

The sign masks a basic reality. The image becomes a distortion of reality.



Stage Three:

The sign marks the *absence* of basic reality. The image calls into question what the reality is and if it even exists.



Stage Four:

The sign bears no relation to any reality whatsoever; it is its own pure simulacrum.

Disneyland as hyperreal (simulation)

‘Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest is real, when in fact all of Los Angeles and the America surrounding it are no longer real, but of the order of the hyperreal and simulation’



Political scandal as hyperreal (dissimulation)



Reality television as hyperreal (implosion)

Real

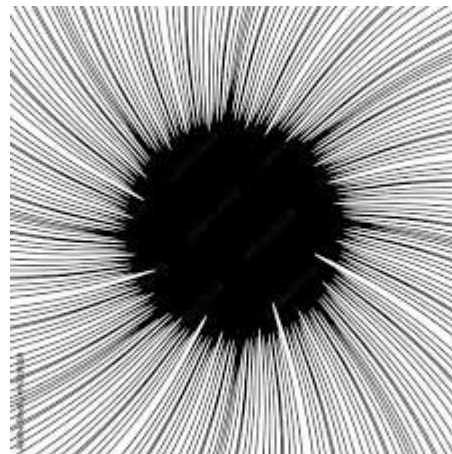


Represented

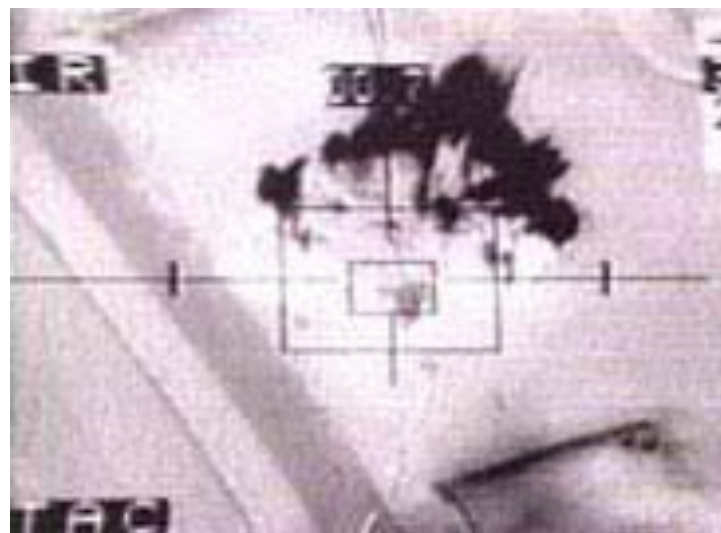
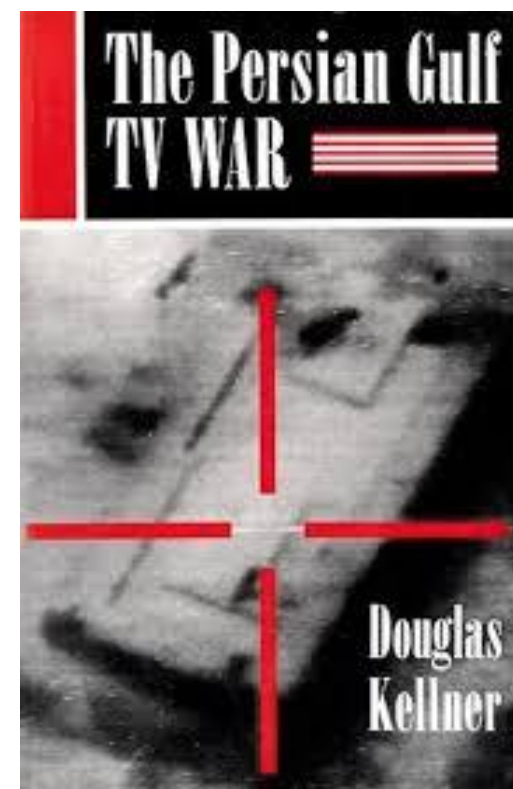


- Real and represented are identical – they implode into one thing, no perceptual distance
- The eye of TV is no longer a panoptic gaze, the gaze is invited, ‘YOU are the content’
- Media stages reality
- What about social media now?

Panopticon



The Gulf War Did Not Take Place (1995)



Jameson's critique of post-modernism

It's easier to imagine the end of the world...

- 'It's easier to imagine the end of the world than an end to capitalism'
- 'It seems easier for us today to imagine the thoroughgoing deterioration of the earth and of nature than the breakdown of late capitalism; perhaps that is due to some weakness in our imaginations' (Jameson, 1994), xii)
- Late Capitalism does not represent a disjuncture with earlier forms of capitalism. In fact, Jameson argued that it is perhaps the 'purest' form of capitalism
- In this phase of capitalism, capital comes to dominate media and cultural production, and hence the sphere of ideas.

Jameson on post-modernism

- Postmodern theory and culture are the primary form of cultural production in Late Capitalism in art, architecture, literature and film.
- These produce an ahistoricism where texts become styles and history is represented through pastiche.
- Alternative (utopian) trajectories for a system other than capitalism collapse into mere fads, narratives, or vague fantasies.

Post-apocalyptic cinema and television

Our consumption of post-apocalyptic cinema and television (and video games) is a parody of our own demise



Imagining capitalism through apocalypse media

Someone once said that it is easier to imagine the end of the world than to imagine the end of capitalism. We can now revise that and witness the attempt to imagine capitalism by way of imagining the end of the world

(Jameson, 2003, pg.76)

The Last of Us (2023)



Fisher: Capitalist Realism

Capitalism dominates all so that it is '*...impossible even to imagine a coherent alternative to it*' (pg.2, author's italics) even post-apocalypse. A 'business ontology' (2009, pg.17) treats everything as a corporation

Capitalism has an absorbent and plastic quality (pg.6) to it, and can incorporate anything, even the apocalypse. Our attempts to think in terms of alternatives are impossible as at the very point of formation of our 'desires, aspirations and hopes' (pg.9) they undergo a process of 'precorporation' (pg.9). Before being incorporated into our consciousness they are already framed by the logic of capitalism.

Hauntology

Fisher uses Derrida's concept of hauntology

Capitalist media is 'haunted' (figuratively) by ideas (ghosts) of former utopias and theorisations: we can't escape modernism / grand narratives?



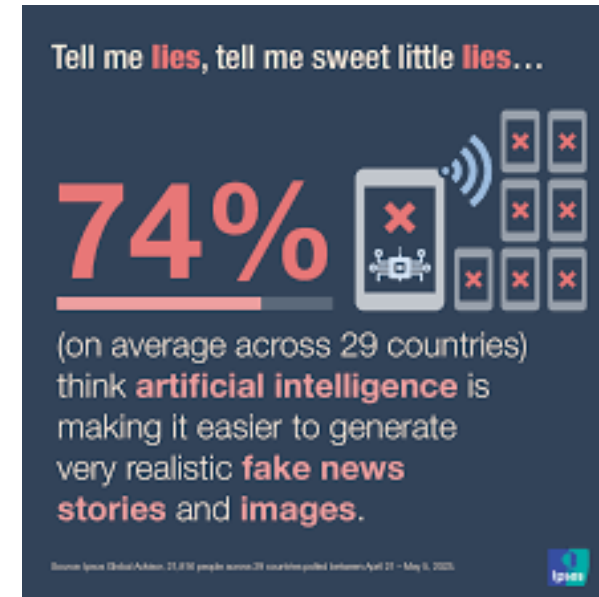


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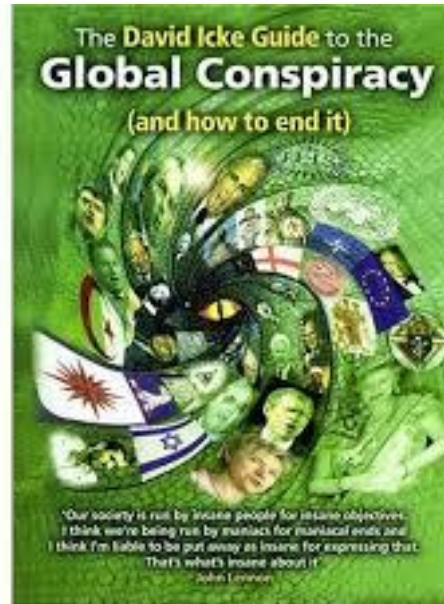
Class16: Postmodernism

Is post-modernism responsible for fake news
/ conspiracy theories / alternative facts...

Fake news / alternative facts / AI

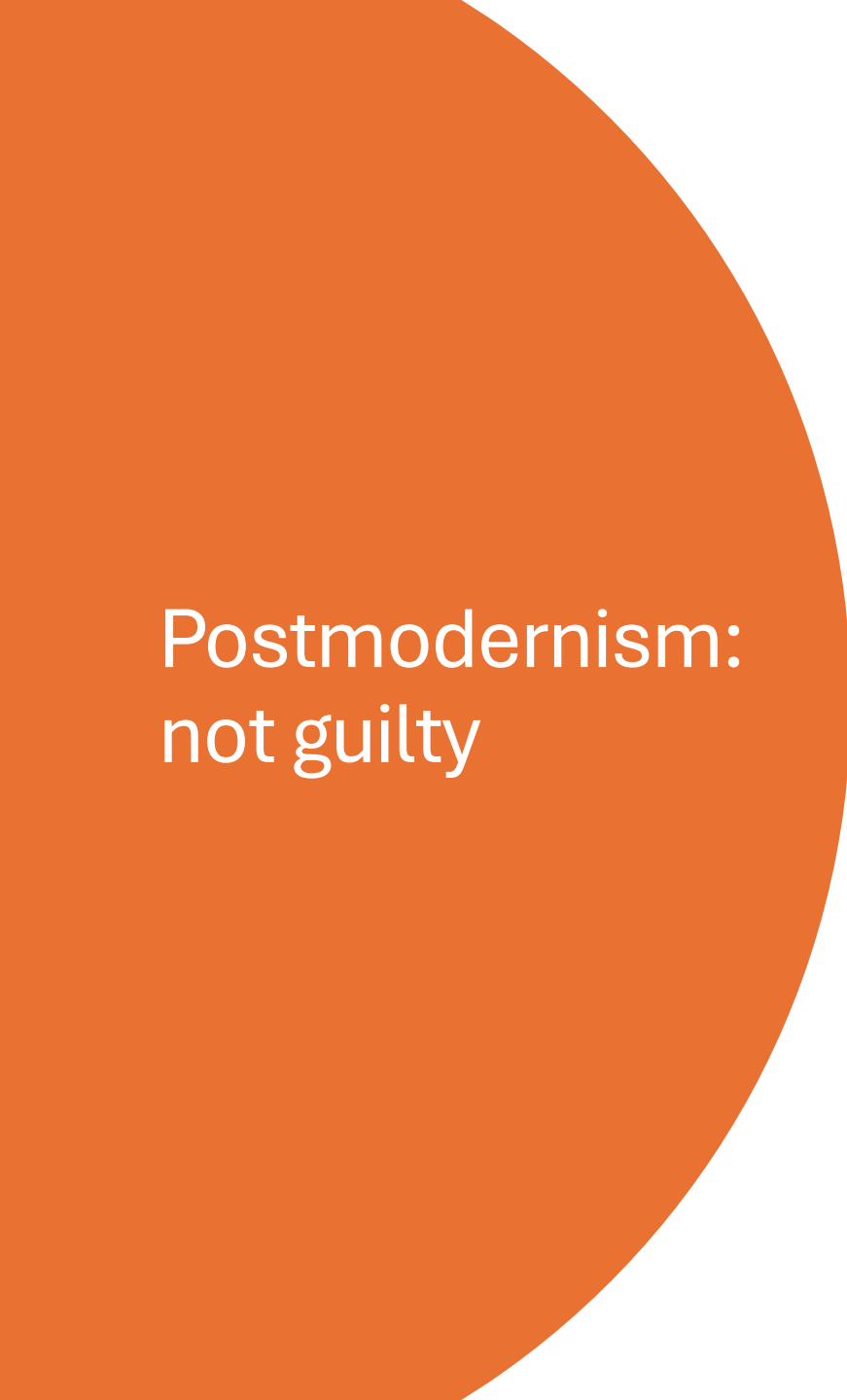


Conspiracy theories



Postmodernism: guilty

- Denies grand narratives – all truth is relative so all theories of equal merit
- Denies alternative counter-narratives (such as Marxism) and so opens the space for alternative political views / facts
- Promotes plurality / polyvocal – therefore all voices are equal
- Obtuse language prevents a popular critique from forming
- More about style than substantive arguments
- Postmodernism is nihilist– denies meaning and is destructive
- Postmodern art / culture was funded by US Government as an alternative to more radical forms of critical theory / Marxism (some evidence for this but may be a 'left' conspiracy theory)



Postmodernism: not guilty

- Critiques grand narratives (nationalism / conspiracy)
 - Provides alternative spaces / modalities of critique
 - Polyvocal and new modalities – alternative spaces of politics
 - Emphasis on flow, shifting identities and agencies – does not replace one form of authoritarianism with another
 - Allows space for different ideas to develop
 - Deflates pomposity with irony
 - Postmodernism is explicitly named by authoritarian governments as leading to identity politics / cultural degeneration
- 

Discussion

- Take an example of a current event in the media where there are multiple interpretations
- What might Lyotard and Baudrillard say about the event and the various interpretations?
- Baudrillard defines a 'pure event' as temporarily breaking the flow of information in hyperreality. He described 9/11 as such a 'pure event', 'the revenge of the real'. Could the current event that you are examining be a 'pure event'?

Post-modernism: key points from the essential reading

Essential reading – key points on media

- Post-modernism as a style (not substance) in media that eschews meta-narratives and linearity of time / space
- Post-modernist cinema emphasises non-linearity, multiple-narratives, pastiche (mixture of styles). *Blade Runner / Pulp Fiction*. In television and advertising emphasises style and surface as well as the above. *Breaking Bad / Only Way Is Essex*
- In pop-music emphasises pastiche, mixture of styles. *Mash-ups / remixing / sampling*
- Exacerbated by media saturation / new occupations – influencer / erosion of mass identities and sub-cultures

Essential reading – limits of post-modernism in explaining media

- Exaggerates the role of media / commercialism in forming reality
- Rehashes claims of Frankfurt School
- Meta-narratives are not in decline
- Divide between high / low culture still remains
- Popular culture has always used mixture of styles
- May overcome some of these limits by bringing in other theories in dialogue with post-modernism. For example, post-structuralism (media as discourse / dialogic), cultural populism (culture as understood through anti-elitism, working class cultures)

Discussion: what are contemporary examples of post-modern cinema / television / music

- Post-modernism in media eschews meta-narratives and linearity of time / space. Post-modernist cinema emphasises non-linearity, multiple-narratives, pastiche. In television and advertising emphasises style and surface as well as the above.

Examples of post-modernism in media

- Pulp Fiction: Contains multiple narratives, no central narrator / truth, uses pastiche (Pulp Fiction) and sets in contemporary setting. In this scene the narrator's face is not shown and the character shown directly hardly speaks subverting perspective [Marsellus Wallace and Butch... Pride only hurts, It never helps.](#)
- Blade Runner: No clear narrative as to who is human, and who is not. Mixes genres (science fiction / detective / existential horror). In this scene Deckard, the Detective tries to determine if Rachel is human or not. No central truth. [Blade Runner \(1982\) Deckard administers the Voight-Kampff test on Rachael](#)
- Breaking Bad: Walter White is a Chemistry Teacher who becomes a meth-manufacturer and dealer who adopts the name 'Heisenberg' as a gangster / criminal. The series asks the question what is our real identity, and do we even have one: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ph7k99uFJBY>
- Girl Talk: Girl Talk is a popular DJ / Artist who creates music by mashing up existing songs. Is this 'new' music in any sense, or does such a thing even exist: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KykbPtRb0K4>